

BIS RAG Knowledge Base — General Introduction & Overview

Scope: What BIS is, its legal basis, structure, and functions — product-agnostic, not tied to any specific IS number or scheme

Purpose: This document answers general/orientation queries such as 'What is BIS', 'Is BIS a government body', 'How are Indian Standards made', or 'What does BIS do' — the kind of question a first-time user asks before narrowing down to a specific product or standard. Use this as the default retrieval source when no specific product/IS number is detected in the user's query.

Compiled: 05 September 2026 | Prototype: SIH26 BIS AI Assistant (Team Byte Busters)

Sources: bis.gov.in (About BIS, BIS Act & Rules, Director General pages), The Bureau of Indian Standards Act, 2016 (Act No. 11 of 2016)

SECTION 1 — What is BIS

[CHUNK TYPE: overview-text] [RAG-TAG: bis_intro, general_overview]

The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) is the National Standards Body of India. It is a statutory organisation established under the Bureau of Indian Standards Act, 2016, and functions under the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, Government of India. BIS is responsible for the harmonious development of standardisation, marking, and quality certification of goods, and for matters connected with or incidental to these activities.

In practical terms, BIS performs three broad roles: (1) it writes and publishes technical specifications called Indian Standards (IS) covering products, processes, systems, and services; (2) it operates certification and registration schemes that let manufacturers demonstrate their products conform to those standards; and (3) it runs consumer-facing and outreach activities such as hallmarking of precious-metal jewellery, laboratory recognition, standards clubs in schools, and training programmes.

Key facts:

- Statutory basis: The Bureau of Indian Standards Act, 2016 (Act No. 11 of 2016), which came into effect on 12 October 2017.
- Ministry: Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, Government of India.
- Headquarters: Manak Bhawan, 9 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi-110002.
- Regional offices: 5 — Kolkata, Chennai, Mumbai, Chandigarh, and Delhi — plus over 20 branch offices across other cities (e.g. Bengaluru, Patna, Jaipur, Hyderabad).
- Director General (Chief Executive Authority): Shri Sanjay Garg, IAS.
- Motto: M^{anakah} Pathapradarsakah (Sanskrit: मानकपथप्रदर्शकः) — roughly, 'Standards are the pathfinder/guide.'

SECTION 2 — History: From ISI to BIS

[CHUNK TYPE: overview-text] [RAG-TAG: history, isi, legacy]

Year	Milestone
1946–1947	Precursor body, the Indian Standards Institution (ISI), set up under a Resolution of the Department of Industries and Supplies (No. 1 Std.(4)/45, dated 3 September 1946); ISI formally began operating in January 1947 and was registered under the Societies Registration Act, 1860.
1955	ISI introduced the Certification Marks Scheme — the origin of what the public still commonly calls the 'ISI Mark' today.
1986–1987	The Bureau of Indian Standards Act, 1986 was enacted; BIS was formally established on 1 April 1987, succeeding ISI as a statutory body (rather than a registered society).
2016–2017	The Bureau of Indian Standards Act, 2016 was notified (22 March 2016) and brought into force from 12 October 2017, replacing the 1986 Act and modernising BIS's mandate — including provisions for compulsory hallmarking, multiple conformity-assessment schemes, and expanded scope (services and systems, not just products).
2018	BIS (Conformity Assessment) Regulations, 2018 notified — the regulatory instrument currently defining the 10 conformity assessment schemes (product certification/ISI, CRS, and others).

SECTION 3 — Legal Framework: The BIS Act, 2016

[CHUNK TYPE: regulation-text] [RAG-TAG: bis_act_2016, legal_basis, governance]

Purpose of the Act (paraphrased): To provide for the establishment of a national standards body for the harmonious development of standardisation, marking, and quality certification of goods and services, and for matters connected therewith.

Key structural provisions:

- **Ex-officio President:** the Union Minister in charge of the Ministry/Department with administrative control of BIS (currently the Minister of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution) serves as the ex-officio President of BIS.
- **Governing Council:** BIS is governed by a Governing Council which oversees policy and overall direction.
- **Director General:** the Director General is designated the Chief Executive Authority of the Bureau, exercising and discharging the Bureau's powers and duties as specified by regulations, and may delegate powers to other officers by written order.
- **Ownership of standards:** Under the Act, the right, title, and interest in every Indian Standard or other BIS publication vests in the Bureau itself.
- **Protection against unauthorized reproduction (Section 11):** No individual may, without BIS's authorisation, publish, reproduce, or record any Indian Standard (or part of it) or any other BIS publication in any manner or form. This is the legal basis for why full IS standard texts are distributed only through BIS's own authorised sales channel (the BSB Edge portal) rather than freely reproduced elsewhere.
- **Accounts and audit:** BIS's accounts are maintained in a form prescribed by the Central Government in consultation with the Comptroller and Auditor-General of India (CAG), and are audited by the CAG.
- **Rules and Regulations:** The Central Government may make rules by Official Gazette notification to carry out the purposes of the Act; every rule and regulation made under the Act must be laid before both Houses of Parliament.
- **500+ scientific officers** work across BIS as Certification Officers, Member Secretaries of technical committees, and laboratory Officers-in-Charge (OICs).

Note for the assistant: if a user asks 'can I photocopy/share an IS standard PDF I bought', the correct answer, grounded in Section 11, is no — reproduction without BIS authorisation is legally restricted, even for a standard the user has purchased for personal viewing.

SECTION 4 — Core Functions of BIS

[CHUNK TYPE: overview-text] [RAG-TAG: functions, mandate, scope_of_work]

Function	What it means in practice
Standards Formulation	Drafting, publishing, and periodically revising Indian Standards (IS) across virtually all sectors — electronics, textiles, food, construction, chemicals, mechanical engineering, etc. — through technical committees composed of industry, government, academia, and consumer representatives.
Product Certification (ISI Mark)	Voluntary-by-default certification (Scheme-I) that becomes mandatory for specific products via a government Quality Control Order (QCO) — testing plus factory inspection, resulting in a licence (CM/L number).
Compulsory Registration (CRS)	Self-declaration-based registration (Scheme-II), mandatory for specified electronics/IT/solar products under MeitY/MNRE orders — lab test report plus BIS registration, resulting in an R-number, generally without factory inspection.
Hallmarking	Purity certification and marking scheme for gold and silver jewellery/artefacts, using a Hallmark Unique ID (HUID) assigned at BIS-recognised Assaying & Hallmarking Centres.
Laboratory Recognition	Recognising private and government testing laboratories as competent to test specific products against specific Indian Standards, enabling the CRS/ISI ecosystem to scale beyond BIS's own labs.
Management Systems Certification	Certifying organisations' quality/environmental/other management systems (distinct from certifying individual products).
Consumer Affairs & Grievance Redressal	Handling consumer complaints about non-conforming or counterfeit certified/registered products, and running consumer-awareness activities.
Training	Delivering training programmes on standardisation, quality management, and certification processes for industry and government personnel.
Standards Clubs / Manak Mitra	School- and community-level outreach initiatives to build early awareness of standardisation and quality among students.
International Standardisation Liaison	Representing India in international standards bodies (ISO, IEC) and aligning Indian Standards with international ones where appropriate (visible in this dataset as 'identical/equivalent' fields on IS standards, e.g. IS 16102 aligning with IEC 62560).

SECTION 5 — Voluntary vs Mandatory Compliance

[CHUNK TYPE: overview-text] [RAG-TAG: mandatory_vs_voluntary, qco_rationale]

BIS certification is, by default, voluntary — a manufacturer may choose to get ISI-certified to signal quality even when not legally required to. However, for a specific list of products, the Central Government makes conformity to the relevant Indian Standard **compulsory** by issuing a Quality Control Order (QCO). The stated grounds for imposing a QCO are: public interest, protection of human, animal, or plant health, safety of the environment, prevention of unfair trade practices, and national security.

This is why the assistant will encounter two different postures depending on the product: some categories (e.g. LED lamps, mobile phones, pressure cookers) are under a mandatory QCO with a specific notified Indian Standard, while many other product categories remain purely voluntary — a manufacturer can apply for an ISI licence to build consumer trust, but is not legally obliged to.

SECTION 6 — How an Indian Standard Is Made

[CHUNK TYPE: process-explanation] [RAG-TAG: standard_development_process, technical_committee]

Indian Standards are developed through a committee-based consensus process, broadly mirroring international standards-body practice (ISO/IEC):

1. BIS organises its standardisation work into Departments (e.g. Electrotechnical Department/ETD, Electronics and Information Technology Department/LITD, and others for chemicals, textiles, civil engineering, food, etc.).
2. Within each department, Sectional Committees (e.g. ETD 23 for Lamps and Related Equipment, LITD 07 for Audio/Video/Multimedia/Communication Equipment) are formed with representatives from large-scale industry, MSMEs, R&D; organisations, academic institutions, central ministries/regulatory bodies, consumer groups, and individuals in personal capacity.
3. A committee drafts a new standard or revises an existing one, often aligning with the equivalent international IEC/ISO standard where one exists (the standard's own cover page records this as 'identical', 'modified/technically equivalent', or similar).
4. Draft standards are typically circulated for wider comment before finalisation (standard ISO/IEC-style public-comment practice; committee-specific procedures vary).
5. On approval, BIS publishes the standard with a formal edition/revision number, and it is filed under the relevant Sectional Committee and Department.
6. Standards are periodically reaffirmed (kept as-is), revised (reissued as a new edition, e.g. 'First Revision', 'Second Revision'), or withdrawn, tracked via BIS's 'Know Your Standard' portal life-cycle view and formal gazette notifications.

Committee composition and meeting schedules are publicly viewable per-committee on the BIS website (e.g. ETD 23 and LITD 07, already captured in the product-specific datasets in this knowledge base) — useful if a user asks a governance-style question not tied to a specific product.

SECTION 7 — Conformity Assessment Schemes: High-Level Overview

[CHUNK TYPE: overview-text] [RAG-TAG: schemes_overview, scheme_count]

Under the BIS (Conformity Assessment) Regulations, 2018 (as periodically amended, including in 2026), BIS operates 10 conformity assessment schemes — 7 focused on products, and 3 focused on systems, services, and processes. This document gives only the high-level map; detailed, product-specific procedural data for Scheme-I (ISI) and Scheme-II (CRS) is maintained separately per product in this knowledge base.

Scheme (common name)	What it is
Scheme-I (ISI Mark)	Product certification via testing + factory inspection + ongoing surveillance; results in a CM/L licence number. India's original and most recognisable certification, in place since 1955.
Scheme-II (CRS)	Compulsory Registration Scheme — self-declaration of conformity based on a lab test report, generally without routine factory inspection; results in an R-number. Used mainly for electronics/IT and solar products.
Schemes III, IV	Variants of product certification, including routes for foreign manufacturers.
Scheme VII	Has a distinct fee structure (flat annual fee with MSME concessions).
Scheme IX	Uses periodic re-certification rather than simple renewal.
Scheme X	Applies to certain regulated machinery/industrial products under QCOs.
Systems/Services/Process Schemes (3 schemes)	Cover certification of management systems and services rather than individual physical products.
Hallmarking Scheme (named, sits outside the numbered product schemes)	Dedicated regulatory framework for gold/silver jewellery purity certification via HUID.
FMCS (Foreign Manufacturers Certification Scheme)	Certification route specifically for manufacturers located outside India.
Eco Mark Scheme	Certification for environmentally friendly products.

For your prototype's scope (per your problem statement), Scheme-I (ISI), Scheme-II (CRS), and Hallmarking are the three most relevant and are covered with full procedural depth in the companion product-specific datasets.

SECTION 8 — Key BIS Digital Touchpoints

[CHUNK TYPE: reference-list] [RAG-TAG: portals, digital_services]

Touchpoint	Purpose
bis.gov.in	Main corporate website — About BIS, Acts & Rules, committee composition, contact directory.
standards.bis.gov.in — Know Your Standard	Look up any Indian Standard by number or keyword: scope, status, life-cycle, classification, labs, licences.
crsbis.in (eBIS)	CRS portal — product list, registration/renewal/inclusion process, recognised labs, registered-manufacturer search.
manakonline.in	Hallmarking registration portal for jewellers; HUID-related services.
BIS Care App	Mobile app for consumers — verify licence/HUID/registration numbers, file complaints, browse products under compulsory certification, find laboratories.
standardsbis.bsbedge.com	Official authorised portal to purchase/download full Indian Standard PDFs (free for indigenous standards, after account registration).

RAG usage note: Chunk each numbered section of this document separately, tagged 'general_bis_overview' rather than any product-specific tag. Route a user query to this document when no specific product name or IS number is detected — e.g. 'what is BIS', 'is BIS government-run', 'how are Indian standards written', 'what's the difference between ISI and CRS' (general form, not tied to a product). Route to the product-specific datasets (LED Lamp/IS 16102, Mobile Phone/IS 13252, etc.) once a product or IS number is mentioned.